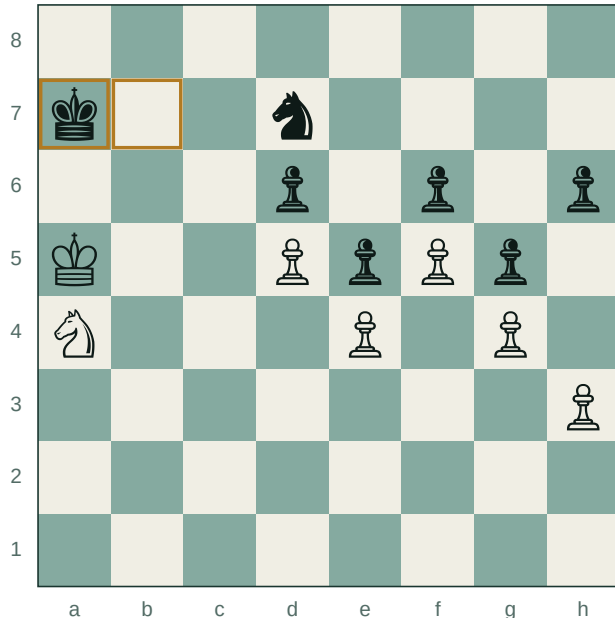


Knight-ending routes: White, move 49

Knight-ending routes

White to move



Previous move: 48...Ka7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

49. Nc3 Kb8 50. Nb5 Nc5 51. Nxd6 Kc7 52. Ne8+

49.Nc3 The knight moves from a4 to c3. Recorded reply: **49...Kb8**.

50.Nb5 The knight moves from c3 to b5. Recorded reply: **50...Nc5**.

51.Nxd6 The knight captures the pawn on d6. Recorded reply: **51...Kc7**.

52.Ne8+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here.

At the end, nominal material is White 8 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on a7. Geometrically undefended: knight on d7. Check for tactical protection.